

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THICK SKIN

On December 25, Delhi was shivering. Yet, Congress leader **Rahul Gandhi** was seen only in a T-shirt while paying tributes to Mahatma Gandhi and former prime ministers, including Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Even during the Bharat Jodo Yatra, amid the chilling winters of north India, Rahul has been seen only in his trademark white T-shirt, while other leaders, including Sonia Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and Mallikarjun Kharge, were seen wearing gloves, mufflers, and jackets. As social media was abuzz wondering what kept Rahul warm, he sought to philosophise: "They keep asking me how I do not feel cold. But they do not ask the farmer, the worker, poor children, this question." But the best answer came from party communication in-charge Jairam Ramesh. He said Rahul had developed a thick skin, surviving the daily assault of the BJP for nearly two decades.

WHAT'S IN A COLOUR?



West Bengal's new governor **C.V. Ananda Bose,** whom chief minister Mamata Banerjee has eulogised as a thorough gentleman, felt uneasy wearing the saffron robe at Jadavpur University's convocation ceremony. With a frown on his face, he said that it was time to get rid of the colonial practices and embrace Indian costume and culture. Many wondered if his discomfiture had anything to do with the colour, often associated with the BJP. While the state BJP has been seeking to paint Bose as PM Narendra Modi's man, the governor has been making efforts to project himself neutral. He has not hesitated to praise Mamata in public. Certainly, Bose doesn't want a coloured assessment of his tenure.

Restless For Reward

The downside of a sweeping victory is the hollowness that follows. Gujarat BJP president **C.R. Paatil** is learnt to be getting restless and is seeking a higher reward than the result itself. It is believed he is eyeing a key role in the organisation, possibly succeeding J.P. Nadda as the next party president. Observers term this target too ambitious for Paatil, given that another top post cannot go to a leader from Gujarat. But they believe he would be rewarded with either a berth in the Union cabinet or a key role in the upcoming elections in Maharashtra, considering his dual identity of a Marathi-origin leader based in Gujarat.

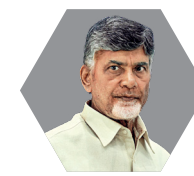


CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



Star-struck

During her visit to Madhya Pradesh's Satpura Tiger Reserve in November, actor Raveena Tandon found herself in a controversy after a complaint was filed regarding her safari vehicle trying to obstruct a tiger's movement. Raveena raised the matter with the Maharashtra forest authorities who spoke to their MP counterparts. Result? MP forest minister **Kunwar Vijay Shah** invited Raveena to a 'forest fair' in Bhopal as a guest and then sent her on a safari to Satpura with his family members. Later, the actor clarified that she was unfairly targeted. This was not the first time Shah displayed star-struck behaviour. In 2020, he had sent a dinner invite to Vidya Balan who was shooting for a film in MP. When the actor declined the invite, he reportedly disallowed the film's shooting, something the minister denied later.



BARGAIN DEAL

After a four-year hiatus, TDP chief **N. Chandrababu Naidu** addressed a well-attended party rally in Telangana's Khammam on December 22. His renewed interest in the state raises prospects of a grand alliance for the 2023 assembly poll with the BJP, which has been aggressive in its goal of ruling the state. By playing the second fiddle, Naidu hopes to get similar support from the BJP, along with Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party, for another alliance to enable the TDP to wrest power in Andhra in 2024.

Kaushik Deka with Romita Datta, Rahul Noronha, Jumana Shah and Amarnath K. Menon